

AIR & SPACE FORCES MAGAZINE







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OK

RQ-4 Global Hawk

The Global Hawk is a strategic long-endurance, high-altitude, “deep look” ISR platform complementing satellite and manned ISR.

The system consists of the aircraft and sensors, launch and recovery element (LRE), mission control element (MCE), and comms/ mission planning cell. 



The preproduction Block 10 debuted in combat in 2001 and retired in 2011. The follow-on Block 20 was initially equipped with the Enhanced Integrated Sensor Suite (EISS) for imagery intelligence (IMINT) and five were eventually converted as EQ-4B Battlefield Airborne Communications Node (BACN) relays, retired in 2021.



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alongside C-27B supporting operations in the EUCOM area of operations, in addition to testing concepts for Arctic surveillance.

RQ-4 Global Hawk Technical Data

Contractors: Northrop Grumman, Raytheon, L3Harris.

First Flight: Feb. 28, 1998.

Delivered: August 2003-present.

IOC: August 2011 (Block 30); August 2016 (Block 40).

Production: 45 (USAF).
Inventory: 9 (Block 40).
Operator: ACC, AFMC.
Aircraft Location: Beale AFB, Calif. (Block 30); Edwards AFB, Calif.; Grand Forks AFB, N.D. (Block 20/40); forward operating locations: Ali Al Salem AB, Kuwait (EQ-4B); Andersen AFB, Guam; NAS Sigonella, Italy; Yokota AB, Japan.
Active Variants: •EQ-4B Block 20. Battlefield Airborne Communications Node (BACN) comm relay platform. •RQ-4B Block 30. Multi-intelligence platform equipped with EO/IR and SAR sensors. •RQ-4B Block 40. AESA and SAR equipped ground moving target indication (GMTI) and battlefield ISR platform.
Dimensions: Span 130.9 ft, length 47.6 ft, height 15.3 ft.
Weight: Max T-O 32 250 lb; max payload 3 000 lb



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US Hits Iranian Boats, Missile Sites; Iran Claims Drone Shootdown

May 26, 2026 | By Chris Gordon

Strategy & Policy: Telling USAF’s Story is a Critical Mission

Feb. 6, 2026 | By John A. Tirpak

WORLD: History

Sept. 12, 2025

Drone Hype and Airpower Amnesia

July 25, 2025 | By Lt. Col. Grant Georgulis, USAF

Lawmakers Urge Air Force, SOCOM to Collaborate on New Long-Range Surveillance Drones

June 23, 2025 | By Rachel S. Cohen



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USAF Experiments with Drones to Better Monitor Russia in the Arctic

Sept. 18, 2024 | By Unshin Lee Harpley

NORAD Boss ‘Intrigued’ by New High-Altitude Drones Amid Increase in Russian Approaches

Sept. 17, 2024 | By Unshin Lee Harpley

In a First, USAF RQ-4 Global Hawk to Operate from UK

Aug. 23, 2024 | By John A. Tirpak

F-35s Lead 50 USAF Aircraft in NATO Air Defense Exercise

May 10, 2024 | By Chris Gordon and Unshin Lee Harpley

Getting Ready for the New Test Surge



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Northrop Won't Bid on Air Force's NGAD Fighter, But CCA, F/A-XX Programs Still in Play

July 27, 2023 | By John A. Tirpak

World: Space

June 22, 2023

USAF Looks to Fill Intelligence Gaps from Space

May 17, 2023 | By Greg Hadley

The Future Force

March 31, 2023 | By John A. Tirpak



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Dec. 2, 2022 | By Heather Penney

Austin: Need to Consider 'Range of Capabilities' in Developing Hypersonic Weapons

May 3, 2022 | By Greg Hadley

RQ-4 Pilot and Instructor Faulted in Crash that Destroyed \$64 Million Drone

April 25, 2022 | By Greg Hadley

2022 Will Be a Big Year for USAF

Jan. 21, 2022 | By John A. Tirpak

RQ-4 Global Hawk Drone Crashes in North Dakota

Aug. 6, 2021 | By Greg Hadley



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Global Hawk Learns New Tricks While Congress Mulls Retirement

Aug. 13, 2020 | By Rachel S. Cohen

Air Force to Continue 'Zero-Based' Budget Reviews

Aug. 3, 2020 | By Rachel S. Cohen

Oil Leak, Improper Mission Planning Caused 2018 RQ-4 Crash

July 20, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

World

July 1, 2020 | By Air & Space Forces Magazine Staff

HASC Floats Modest Modernization, New Sustainment Jobs



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Goldfein on How USAF Is Generating Airpower in the 'New Abnormal'

April 15, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

CENTCOM, AFRICOM Urge Lawmakers Not to Cut MQ-9, Combat Air Patrols

March 10, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine and Rachel S. Cohen

Goldfein Defends USAF Decision to Retire Legacy Aircraft

March 4, 2020 | By Amy Hudson

World

March 1, 2020 | By Air & Space Forces Magazine Staff

Goldfein: Take Risk Now to Buy Future Capability



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Legacy Fleets Take Hit to Pay for RDT&E Funding Boost

Feb. 10, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

DOD Budget Invests in Space, Nuclear Modernization, Multi-Domain Operations

Feb. 10, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

The Bone is Back

Feb. 1, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

NATO Receives First Air Ground Surveillance Aircraft

Jan. 17, 2020 | By Brian W. Everstine

Congress Looks to Bolster USAF Drone Development in 2020



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New Global Hawk Wing Charts Path to Maturity

Oct. 15, 2019 | By Rachel S. Cohen

USAF Portfolio Expands in Libya Operation

March 29, 2011

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